

STATEMENT OF TEACHING PHILOSOPHY

I teach my classes with the following goals, methods, and assessments.

I. Goals for student learning

An important goal for me as an educator is to empower every student in my class to pursue their academic and professional goals. To that end, I design my courses such that there is sufficient theoretical underpinning for students to pursue the subject further independently if they want, but also ample empirical exposure in research, modelling and presentation skills that will help them break into the workforce. Additionally, being an applied Microeconomist, I like to ensure that students pick up basic software skills, become aware of common data sources, get comfortable with data manipulation, and start writing reports.

I try to achieve my goals for student learning by striking a balance between sharing **insights** on the subject while keeping the audience **inspired**. I believe that these two complementary values make education a **joyful** experience and can help individuals unfold their genius. Inspiration results in students becoming more active learners and increases their appetite to explore, which I try to utilize by curating material and choosing appropriate methods to communicate the insights. Thus, I am always paying attention to the study topics, choice of examples, medium of communication and the delivery style – trying to achieve a sweet spot between insights and inspiration so that a virtuous, productive learning loop is established.

II. Enactment of goals (teaching methods)

I build everything up from first principles for **simplicity** and supplement the material with examples students can **relate** to so that they can truly appreciate existing economic thought. And I try to connect with each student, partly by being accessible outside the class too so that I can guide and **inspire** them to develop a passion for the subject and enjoy the learning process.

First, for the **simplicity** aspect, I emphasize organization of the material before every lecture so that students can form clear mind maps – why are we studying a topic, how is it structured and connected with prior or future material? Usually, I begin a lecture by painting the larger picture through doing quick reviews at beginning of the class to refresh everyone's memory. After building the telescopic view, we delve into specific lesson details, but close again with a quick recap of what lies ahead. Also, while I emphasize the simplest definition or approach to explain a key concept, I do introduce alternative ways to look at the concept if it strengthens understanding. Apart from building the students' appreciation of mathematical modelling, first principles driven simplicity usually is appreciated when covering slightly advanced concepts like the best fit line in *Econometrics*, information asymmetry in *Principles of Microeconomics* or playing out of monetary policy in *Principles of Macroeconomics*.

Second, I highlight real world applications in my course material like lectures, problem sets and worksheets that are common, interesting or important so that the students can **relate** with the subject because of their relevance - either because of its contemporary nature or their own life stage. For example, sometimes I might share news articles or online resources to help students make deeper connection between their surroundings and the toy model taught in class or discussed in the textbook. At other times, I might engage the class in discussions that bring in a flavor of more advanced topics from Industrial Organization, Labor Economics or Developmental Economics, and provide enough references so that these topics can be explored to better internalize the concepts. As much as possible, I try to showcase the usefulness of the concepts in multiple settings, their historical origin, and at times even their limitations to encourage students to pursue the subject further.

Third, apart from providing simple and relatable insights, keeping my students **inspired** is equally important for me so that they can become self-driven independent learners. Towards this goal, I find that being a bit more empathetic in my personal interactions with students and truly believing in their capability goes far in inspiring them and ultimately enhancing their performance. Thus, I treat all my students with respect, acknowledge their unique backgrounds and encourage them to find their niche. I treat all students as capable young individuals who can succeed, which often has a self-fulfilling effect.

I also encourage students by creating a class community using discussion boards and group projects where we all learn from each other. Graded discussion boards ensure that the course is energized with fresh perspectives

or different perspectives, and taps into the collective wisdom of the class. Furthermore, group assignments are opportunities for the students to collaborate/learn from each other, and get exposure to the real-world work environment. Often these initiatives have been appreciated by students, even in my asynchronous online courses.

Additionally, I motivate students by showing passion for the subject myself during lectures and keeping my office availability high. How can I expect my students to spend hours on the material outside the classroom if I am not invested in the material? Furthermore, to make the simple, relatable insights even more digestible so that students stay intellectually inspired to learn even more, I create and curate resources for the benefits of the students, or follow up with individuals students if I miss something.

III. Assessment of goals (measuring student learning)

In terms of student assessment, I realize that there is no perfect information extraction process, but nonetheless I usually implement a few principles mentioned below.

First, I avoid using a single assessment criteria like timed multiple choice question exams in favor of a more **diversified assessment** criteria to better include students who would have trouble expressing themselves in a particular format. Thus, often the final grade in my courses comes from various distinct assessments such as exams, student classroom presentations, online discussion board activity, group projects and/or active participation. Furthermore, my **detailed feedback/responses** have been well received by students which is why I strive to continue providing atleast some qualitative assessment in a timely manner, as for me late feedback is as good as none and I like to see my students improving from their mistakes quickly.

Second, I design my key assignments and exams such that **systematic** and **critical thinking skills** are rewarded over memorization or guesswork. For example, take home assignments build strong organizational skills - questions have many subparts and upon successful completion, students would have built a comprehensive analytical toolkit. On the other hand, timebound exams are designed to check if the student can make new learning or application connections including interpreting equations. Furthermore, I try to **remove the exam pressure** from students by being flexible on when/where students can take it and making my exams open book, but have a zero-tolerance policy for academic dishonesty such as collusion as I believe long term success comes from systematic hard work and violation of basic integrity will only create a shaky foundation in the long run.

Third, I usually follow a **maxi-min** grading criterion. I tend to pay special attention to the students that are struggling in the course - meeting them outside regular class hours, inviting them personally to my office hours, engaging them specifically in class, and try to work more closely with them in multiple ways.

In summary, I ensure that students have built a strong understanding of the world around them through an Economics lens in my course. I try to generate a positive course experience by keeping students highly encouraged and engaged - providing them with simple, relatable insights to preserve the joy of learning and giving them appropriate timely feedback. I believe in making knowledge more accessible. Ultimately, I attempt to transform individuals into more independent learners and potential future leaders.